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Ahobilam

Ahobilam is a town and holy site in the Allagadda mandal of Nandyal district in the Indian state of Andhra Pradesh.[1] It is surrounded by the Eastern Ghats with several mountain hills and gorges. It is the centre of worship of Narasimha, the lion-headed avatar of Vishnu, along with his consort Pratyangira, an avatar of Lakshmi. It is one of the nine Hindu temples and shrines dedicated to this deity. The main village and a temple complex are at Lower Ahobilam. Upper Ahobilam, about 8 kilometres to the east, has more temples in a steep gorge.[2] The site has evidence of historical patronage from a number of regional dynasties, with the most significant being that of the Vijayanagara Kingdom.

Ahobilam
1st Nava Narasimha Temple

Town

Upper Ahobilam temple Gopuram

Location in Andhra Pradesh, India
Coordinates: 15.1333°N 78.7167°E

Country	India
State	Andhra Pradesh
District	Nandyal
Elevation	327 m (1,073 ft)
Population	
• **Total**	3,732
Languages	
• **Official**	Telugu
Time zone	UTC+5:30 (IST)
Vehicle registration	AP
Website	http://ahobilamtemple.com

History

The history of Ahobilam before the 16th century is obscure. One of the earliest literary references to Ahobilam is in the 9th-century Tamil-language religious work *Periyatirumoḻi* written by Thirumangai Alvar, where it is eulogized; this led to it being codified as one of the 108 canonical *Divya Desams*. Ahobilam finds subsequent mention in several Sanskrit and Telugu-language texts between the 12th and 16th centuries.[3][4]

Inscriptions and other material evidence indicate that the shrines of the town received patronage from the Kakatiya and Reddi dynasties during the 13th and 14th centuries. The historical record is more prominent during the Vijayanagara period. The site received significant patronage from rulers of the Vijayanagara kingdom, starting with the Saluva dynasty in the 15th century, and sustained by the Tuluva dynasty in the 16th century. Most inscriptions at the shrines date to the Tuluva period. The ruler Krishnadevaraya visited and patronised the town's shrines in the 16th century. The town is also

the birthplace of the Ahobila Matha, a monastic institution founded during the medieval period; scholars have proposed the late 15th or early 16th century as the possible periods of origin.[4]

Ahobilam lost imperial patronage with the decline of the Vijayanagara kingdom.[5] The site faced a raid in 1579 by Murahari Rao, a commander of the Golconda Sultanate. Ahobilam's temple was sacked and its bejewelled idol presented to Golconda's sultan.[6]

Geography

Ahobilam is located at 15.1333°N 78.7167°E.[7] It is located in Nallamala Forest, along the Eastern Ghats.[8]

Structure and shrines

The town of Ahobilam is home to ten shrines of Narasimha, the man-lion incarnation of the god Vishnu in Hinduism. The town can be divided into Lower and Upper Ahobilam, which are separated from each other by 8 km. Upper Ahobilam refers to a forested area that sprawls up a ravine. The area is marked by nine different shrines of Narasimha representing nine aspects of the deity, as follows:[4][9]

Entrance to the Prahladavarada temple

- *Ahobilanarasiṃha*
- *Bhārgavanarasiṃha*
- *Jvālānarasiṃha*
- *Yogānandanarasiṃha*
- *Chatravātanarasiṃha*
- *Karañjanarasiṃha*
- *Pāvananarasiṃha*
- *Mālolanarasiṃha*
- *Vārāhanarasiṃha*

Close-up shot of *Ugra stambham* peak at Ahobilam, Nallamala Hills

The shrine of *Ahobilanarasimha* is the earliest shrine of Ahobilam, and is dedicated to the *ugra* (ferocious) aspect of Narasimha.[4]

Lower Ahobilam is contiguous with the populated area of the town, and hosts the town's main pilgrimage attraction, termed the *Prahlādavarada* temple. This shrine dates primarily to the 16th century; its construction may have begun during the reign of Saluva Narasimha Deva Raya, first member of the Saluva dynasty, around the 15th/16th century. It is the last of the shrines built at Ahobilam. It is dedicated to the *saumya* (mild) aspect of Narasimha. Most inscriptions at Ahobilam are found at this temple.[4][9]

Notes

1. "Book on Ahobilam temple released" (https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/tamil-nadu/book-on-ahobilam-temple-released/article26444528.ece). *The Hindu*. 6 March 2019. ISSN 0971-751X (https://search.worldcat.org/issn/0971-751X). Retrieved 17 May 2019.
2. Michell, 330
3. Dębicka-Borek, Ewa (15 December 2023). "Storied Hills: On Landscape, Narratives and Sacredness of Ahobilam" (https://journals.akademicka.pl/cis/article/view/5491). *Cracow Indological Studies*. **25** (1): 113–158. doi:10.12797/CIS.25.2023.01.04 (https://doi.org/10.12797%2FCIS.25.2023.01.04). ISSN 2449-8696 (https://search.worldcat.org/issn/2449-8696).
4. Ambach, Malini; Buchholz, Jonas; Hüsken, Ute; Nachimuthu, K.; Ganesan, T.; Sarma, S. a. S.; Czerniak-Drożdżowicz, Marzenna; Sathyanarayanan, R.; Dębicka-Borek, Ewa (20 October 2022). "Connected Places, Networks of Shrines: Ahobilam in the Nets of Spatial Relationships" (https://hasp.ub.uni-heidelberg.de/catalog/book/906/chapter/13941). *Temples, Texts, and Networks: South Indian Perspectives* (https://books.ub.uni-heidelberg.de/index.php/xa/catalog/book/906/c13941). Heidelberg Asian Studies Publishing. doi:10.11588/hasp.906.c13941 (https://doi.org/10.11588%2Fhasp.906.c13941). ISBN 978-3-948791-23-0.
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7. "redirect to /world/IN/02/Pedda_Ahobilam.html" (https://www.fallingrain.com/world/IN/02/Pedda_Ahobilam.html). *fallingrain.com*.
8. KUMAR, R. SANDEEP (9 September 2018). "Ahobilam: A journey into spirituality" (https://www.deccanchronicle.com/nation/in-other-news/090918/ahobilam-a-journey-into-spirituality.html). *Deccan Chronicle*. Retrieved 17 May 2019.
9. Michell, George (10 August 2012). *Southern India* (https://www.google.com/books/edition/Southern_India/GdBbBAAAQBAJ?hl=en&gbpv=0). Roli Books Private Limited. ISBN 978-81-7436-903-1.

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